BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

# Bar and Bat Mitzvah Planning Kit

*A 12 to 18 month plan for the service, the party, and everything in between*

A bar or bat mitzvah is a meaningful milestone and a big gathering at the same time. This kit helps you balance the religious service with the celebration, keep kids and adults comfortable, and stay on budget. Always follow your synagogue, rabbi, and family customs where they differ from this general guide.

INSIDE


1. 12 to 18 Month Timeline
2. Service Planning Checklist
3. Party Planning Checklist
4. Kids Zone and Adult Zone
5. Rentals Table
6. Budget Split
7. Questions to Ask Vendors
8. Event Worksheet





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PART 1

# 12 to 18 Month Timeline

Synagogue dates and popular party venues often book more than a year ahead.

### *15 to 18 months out*

- [ ] Meet with your synagogue to confirm the service date, study schedule, and requirements.
- [ ] Talk with your child about what they want for the service and the party.
- [ ] Set a total budget and decide who is contributing.
- [ ] Choose possible party dates and tour venues.
- [ ] Ask about kosher requirements at the synagogue and venue.
- [ ] Start a master guest list with family, friends, and classmates.

### *12 to 14 months out*

- [ ] Book the party venue and review the contract.
- [ ] Reserve the caterer, or confirm that the venue provides kosher or kosher-style options.
- [ ] Hire a DJ, band, or MC who has experience with mitzvah parties.
- [ ] Book the photographer and videographer.
- [ ] Start gathering photos for a slideshow.
- [ ] Create a shared folder for contracts and contacts.

### *8 to 10 months out*

- [ ] Choose a theme, color palette, and overall style.
- [ ] Book entertainment such as photo booth, game stations, or activities for kids.
- [ ] Plan a candle lighting ceremony and who will be honored.
- [ ] Choose invitation designs and order them.
- [ ] Discuss honors for the service, such as aliyot, and who will be asked.
- [ ] Plan a family tikkun olam or community service project if desired.

### *5 to 7 months out*

- [ ] Order rentals: tables, chairs, linens, and lounge furniture.
- [ ] Schedule outfit shopping for the child and family.
- [ ] Plan transportation and lodging for out-of-town guests.
- [ ] Order centerpieces and decorations.
- [ ] Plan the cake or dessert display.
- [ ] Book hair and makeup if desired.

### *3 to 4 months out*

- [ ] Mail invitations with an RSVP date about 4 weeks before the event.
- [ ] Confirm the full day schedule from service to party.
- [ ] Choose music for the entrance, candle lighting, hora, and other highlights.
- [ ] Create a do-not-play list for the DJ.
- [ ] Plan kids' activities and the adult dining experience.
- [ ] Order favors and giveaways.

*4 to 8 weeks out*

- [ ] Track RSVPs and call people who have not replied.
- [ ] Create a seating chart draft with kids and adults sections.
- [ ] Print programs for the service.
- [ ] Confirm all vendors and share the schedule.
- [ ] Rehearse at the synagogue with the rabbi or cantor.
- [ ] Prepare a thank-you speech or family remarks.

*The final week*

- [ ] Give the final headcount to the venue and caterer.
- [ ] Print place cards and table numbers.
- [ ] Confirm rental delivery and setup times.
- [ ] Pack an emergency kit with safety pins, tissues, water, and snacks.
- [ ] Check the Chicago forecast and plan for coats and parking.
- [ ] Prepare envelopes for vendor tips and payments.

*After the event*

- [ ] Send thank-you notes within a few weeks.
- [ ] Return rentals and attire on time.
- [ ] Order prints, albums, or the final video.
- [ ] Make donations or complete any planned service project.

PART 2

# Service Planning Checklist

Your synagogue will guide the order and requirements of the service.

## BEFORE THE SERVICE

- [ ] Confirm tallit, kippot, and any required attire.
- [ ] Share the schedule with family and honored guests.
- [ ] Ask about seating for the family and where honorees will sit.
- [ ] Order printed programs or explanatory booklets for guests who may be unfamiliar.
- [ ] Plan arrival and parking for guests.
- [ ] Ask about photography rules inside the sanctuary.
- [ ] Pack a bag with tissues, water, and a spare outfit.

## HONORS AND PARTICIPATION

- [ ] List family members and friends who will receive honors.
- [ ] Share instructions and practice materials with those honorees.
- [ ] Plan a short speech or d'var Torah with your child.
- [ ] Decide on a gift or blessing for the child.
- [ ] Arrange for candy throwing if allowed by your synagogue.

## AFTER THE SERVICE

- [ ] Plan a kiddush or reception right after the service.
- [ ] Provide a transition plan from synagogue to party venue.
- [ ] Allow time for photos and changing outfits.
- [ ] Plan a break so the family can rest between events.
- [ ] Plan winter coat storage and parking if the service is in colder months.

PART 3

# Party Planning Checklist

### VENUE AND FLOW

- [ ] Choose a floor plan with dining, dancing, and a kids' area.
- [ ] Plan the grand entrance and introduction.
- [ ] Reserve a dance floor sized for guests.
- [ ] Plan the candle lighting, hora, and toasts.
- [ ] Schedule the cake cutting and desserts.
- [ ] Leave enough quiet space for older guests.
- [ ] Plan where gifts and cards will be collected securely.

### FOOD AND DRINK

- [ ] Confirm kosher or kosher-style requirements.
- [ ] Plan kid-friendly foods and a separate station if desired.
- [ ] Include vegetarian and allergy-friendly options.
- [ ] Provide nonalcoholic drinks and mocktails.
- [ ] Plan late-night snacks for the dance floor.
- [ ] Label foods clearly.

### ENTERTAINMENT

- [ ] Book an MC who can engage both kids and adults.
- [ ] Plan dance contests and group activities.
- [ ] Include a photo booth or game stations.
- [ ] Prepare a slideshow or video.
- [ ] Create a playlist with input from the guest of honor.

### RENTALS AND SETUP

- [ ] Confirm table count and sizes for the guest count.
- [ ] Choose linens and chair styles to match the theme.
- [ ] Reserve a dance floor, staging, and lighting.
- [ ] Plan lounge seating for teens and a quiet area for grandparents.
- [ ] Order table numbers, centerpieces, and place card stands.
- [ ] Confirm load-in times and who will receive deliveries.

PART 4

# Kids Zone and Adult Zone

Giving each group their own space helps everyone enjoy the party.

| Area | Kids zone | Adult zone |
|---|---|---|
| Seating | Round tables near the dance floor with friends | Tables farther from the speakers, with extra chairs for grandparents |
| Food | Kid-friendly menu, finger foods, snack station | Plated or buffet meal with adult beverages |
| Activities | Games, photo booth, dance floor, DJ contests | Quiet lounge area, cocktail space, conversation corners |
| Music volume | Higher energy near the dance floor | Lower volume in the lounge and dining areas |
| Supervision | A few trusted adult chaperones | Hosts and family members mingle |
| Restrooms | Clearly signed and close to the dance floor | Accessible and quiet |

PART 5

# Rentals Table

Rough planning guidelines. Your venue, floor plan, and guest mix will change the numbers.

| Item | 75 guests | 150 guests | 200 guests |
|---|---|---|---|
| Chairs | 75 | 150 | 200 |
| Round tables of 8 to 10 | 8 to 10 | 15 to 19 | 20 to 25 |
| Head table or family table | 1 | 1 | 1 |
| Cocktail tables | 4 | 8 | 10 |
| Buffet or station tables | 4 | 6 | 8 |
| Linens (tablecloths and napkins) | To match tables | To match tables | To match tables |
| Dance floor | 12 x 12 ft | 16 x 16 ft | 20 x 20 ft |
| Lounge seating groups | 1 to 2 | 2 to 3 | 3 to 4 |
| Dinnerware and glassware sets | 75 | 150 | 200 |
| Photo booth or activity space | 1 | 1 to 2 | 2 |

PART 6

# Budget Split

A starting point for planning. Costs vary widely by venue, guest count, and style.



| Category | Share | Your budget: $_____ | Tip |
|---|---|---|---|
| Venue, food, and beverage | 42% | $_____ | Ask about kosher options, per-person pricing, and service charges. |
| Entertainment (DJ or band, MC, activities) | 14% | $_____ | Confirm the number of hours and any extra costs for lighting or sound. |
| Photography and video | 10% | $_____ | Ask what is included for the service and the party. |
| Rentals and decor | 14% | $_____ | Chairs, linens, dance floor, and lounge pieces make a big impact. |
| Attire, hair, and makeup | 6% | $_____ | Include outfits for both the service and the party. |
| Invitations, favors, and gifts | 5% | $_____ | Digital invitations can cut costs while still looking polished. |
| Synagogue fees and honors | 3% | $_____ | Ask about any donation guidelines and program printing. |
| Transportation and lodging help | 3% | $_____ | Group shuttle options can ease parking in Chicago. |
| Contingency | 3% | $_____ | Keep a cushion for extras. |

PART 7

## Questions to Ask Vendors

1. Do you have experience with mitzvah parties and the service-to-party transition?
2. What kosher or kosher-style options are available, and is there a supervision fee?
3. How many hours does the package include, and how much is overtime?
4. Can you provide a separate kids' menu and station?
5. What time can rentals be delivered, and when will they be picked up?
6. Is a dance floor included, or does it need to be rented separately?
7. What is the policy for outside desserts or specialty items?
8. What is your cancellation and rescheduling policy?

PART 8

## Event Worksheet

CHILD'S NAME AND HEBREW NAME

SERVICE DATE, TIME, AND LOCATION

PARTY DATE, TIME, AND VENUE

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

RABBI OR CANTOR CONTACT

CATERER AND MENU NOTES

DJ OR BAND CONTACT

PHOTOGRAPHER AND VIDEOGRAPHER

RENTAL COMPANY AND DELIVERY WINDOW

CANDLE LIGHTING HONOREES

SEATING CHART DEADLINE

TOTAL BUDGET AND DEPOSITS PAID

NEXT STEP

### Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.